Sharing your story on Lantern

Xolace

October 19, 2026

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One moment. What happened. What it taught you.

Lantern stories are real experiences, told by the people who lived them, so someone going through the same thing feels less alone.

We're not asking for your life story. We're asking for **one experience** that changed how you see something, told honestly.

It can come from any part of life: school, work, family, loss, money, faith, health, relationships, moving, parenting, starting over. It doesn't need to be dramatic. It needs to be true, and it needs to be yours.

The shape

Every good story we've published follows the same four steps.

1. Before. Where were you? What were you carrying, or what did you believe? Keep this short. A few lines is enough.

2. The moment. The day, the conversation or the turning point. Where were you, who was there, and what was said? Help the reader see it.

3. After. What changed, or what you did next. It's fine if it's still unresolved. Some of the strongest stories end with "I'm still working through this."

4. What you'd tell someone in that place now. One or two things the story itself taught you. Not general advice. Something only your experience could teach.

What makes a story work

- **It's about one experience.** One season, one friendship, one phone call. Not everything that ever happened to you.
- **It has at least one real scene,** with the place, the people and the words that were said. "Hey, can we join you?" says more than "I made some friends."
- **It's honest about the hard part.** Stay with it for a moment. Don't rush to the lesson.

- **The takeaway comes from what happened to you.** If the lesson could be pasted onto someone else's story, it's too general.
- **Length: 600 to 1,500 words.** Write it, or record a voice note and we'll help you shape it.

Please avoid

- **A list of tips with no story behind it.** The story is what makes the advice believable.
- **Quotes, studies and statistics.** Your experience is the evidence.
- **Promoting anything,** including Xolace.
- **Graphic detail about self-harm, suicide or violence.** You can say it happened without describing how.
- **Identifying people who didn't agree to be in it.** Change names if you need to. You can also publish anonymously.

Relationship stories

Many of the stories readers connect with most are about people: a best friend, the friends who carried someone through school, a parent who finally listened. Relationship stories are welcome in every form: friendship, romance, family, mentors, colleagues, faith communities, and people you've lost.

They need a little extra care, because the other person can't tell their side.

- **Make it about what you learned, not what they did wrong.** A breakup or falling-out story works when it's about your part and what changed in you. It shouldn't settle a score.
- **Show the relationship in a moment.** One afternoon, one conversation, one thing they said that stayed with you. That does more than a list of reasons they mattered.
- **Protect the other person.** Change names and details that could identify them, especially for exes, family conflict, or anyone still in your life. If they're named, it's best if they know and agree.

- **Loss stories are welcome.** Writing about someone who has died, like a friend, a parent or a sibling, is one of the most powerful things a reader can find. Share what you're comfortable sharing, and tell us if their family should be consulted.
- **It can be a good relationship.** Not every relationship story has to be about pain. The friend who showed up, the mentor who took a chance on you, the group that made you better: these count.

Relationship prompts

- Someone who showed up when you needed it most
- A friendship that ended, and what you understand about it now
- The person who changed your direction without knowing it
- A conversation with a parent or family member that shifted something
- Someone you lost, and what you carry from them
- A relationship you stayed in too long, or left too soon
- The group of people who made you better than you'd have been alone

Not sure which story to tell?

- A day you'd go back and tell your younger self about
- Something you carried alone for too long
- A conversation that changed your direction
- A time you were wrong about yourself
- A moment you realised you weren't okay, and what you did next

What happens next

1. Send your story, written or as a voice note.
2. We edit lightly for clarity and length. Your voice stays yours.
3. You see and approve the final version before anything is published.
4. You choose how you're credited: full name, first name only, or anonymous.